journalists were assigned by the Pentagon to cover the war. Prokov recounted what he heard to one of the TASS correspondents he knew. Anatoly Gorsky was, in reality, a KGB officer. The message Gorsky passed on was that an American invasion of Cuba would begin the following day. This information, was of course, mistaken, but nevertheless found its way to Nikita Khrushchev's in-tray. By that time, the Presidium had already reached its decision to withdraw, but the information may have contributed to Khrushchev's concern that swift action was necessary to avoid war. The incident reflects on the limitations of Soviet intelligence on the Kennedy administration, as well as how in a crisis misinformation travels fast.

Blind moles

Premier Khrushchev's letter to President Kennedy on 26 October was some 2,700 words long. The language was ambiguous, verbose, and characteristically strewn with analogies and metaphors. McNamara described it as 'twelve pages of fluff'. Some members of ExComm were concerned that the Soviet Premier was under serious stress. Dean Acheson and Robert McNamara later speculated he might have been drunk when he wrote the message (shades of Premier Kissof).

The letter was indeed in Khrushchev's inimical style. However, it reflected the Presidium's agreement on Thursday, 25 October that the missiles should be withdrawn in return for Kennedy's assurances not to invade Cuba. Khrushchev circulated a draft to colleagues in the Presidium, though there was no further discussion before it was handed to the US Embassy. It nevertheless reflected the view of the Soviet government, not just Nikita Khrushchev.

The letter contained a formula that seemed consistent with the one that Scali delivered to the State Department:

> If assurances were given by the President and the government of the United States that the USA itself would not participate in an attack on Cuba and would restrain others from actions of this sort, if you would recall your fleet, this would immediately change